Brothers and Burdens

The Spirit-filled community that gently restores a brother overtaken in sin also expects each believer, without comparison or self-deception, to carry and one day give account for his own work before the Lord.

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Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 The Ground of Liberty	**02** 1:6–10 The One True Gospel	**03** 1:11–17 Paul's Independent Revelation	**04** 1:18–2:10 Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches
05 2:11–21 Peter Goes Back to School	**06** 3:1–5 Under a Spell	**07** 3:6–14 Blessing or a Curse	**08** 3:15–29 The Superiority of the Promise to the Law
09 4:1–11 When I Became a Man	**10** 4:12–20 A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove	**11** 4:21–31 Paul's Old Testament Story	**12** 5:1–12 Taking a Stand in Liberty
13 5:13–26 Walk in the Spirit	**14** 6:1–5 Brothers and Burdens	**15** 6:6–10 Sowing and Reaping	**16** 6:11–18 Teaching the Truth

Two burdens, two Greek words

Galatians 6:2 and 6:5 · The key to the passage

“Bear one another's burdens” — v.2

βάρη barē · a crushing weight

- Too heavy for one person to lift
- Calls for the help of the body
- So fulfill the law of Christ

“Each one shall bear his own load” — v.5

φορτίον phortion · a soldier's own pack

- Carried by him alone
- Personal stewardship and service
- Accountability at the judgment seat of Christ

Help with what is unbearable — and carry what is yours. Both are true at once.

Restoring a brother

Galatians 6:1 · Outline I.A — The exhortation

The sinning believer	The spiritual believer	The goal	The manner
προλημφθῇ “overtaken in any trespass” — a slip, caught by surprise	**πνευματικοί** Walking in the Spirit (5:16–25) — not sinless	**καταρτίζετε** Restore — mend the net, set the bone	**πραΰτητος** In gentleness, considering yourself
6:1a	*6:1b*	*6:1c*	*6:1d*

Restoration, never condemnation — gentleness guards against harshness toward him and pride in us.

The law of Christ and the self-deceived

Galatians 6:2–3 · Outline I.B — The explanation

v.2a	“Bear one another's burdens”	**βάρη** too heavy to carry alone
v.2b	“and so fulfill the law of Christ”	**ἀναπληρώσατε** fill up to full measure
v.3a	“If anyone thinks himself to be something, when he is nothing”	the danger after helping
v.3b	“he deceives himself”	**φρεναπατᾷ** self-fancy · used only here

The Christian army is said to be the only army that shoots its wounded. Let's not shoot our wounded.

Examine your own work

Galatians 6:4–5 · Outline II — Bear your own burden

Examination	Exaltation	Explanation
δοκιμαζέτω Test your own work — your service, not your salvation	**καύχημα** Rejoicing in yourself alone, not by comparing with another	**φορτίον** “Each one shall bear his own load”
v.4a	*v.4b*	*v.5*

Assurance does not come from self-examination

- It rests on God's promise to the one who believes — the examination here is about stewardship and reward

Discuss and apply

Galatians 6:1–5 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Think of a time someone gently restored you after a failure. What made it feel like restoration rather than condemnation?

2. Is there a burden in your life right now too heavy to carry alone? Who could you ask to help carry it?

Apply

Restore, Don't Gossip
If a brother or sister has been overtaken, go to them privately and gently before mentioning it to anyone else.

Carry What's Too Heavy, Alone What's Yours
Ask someone specific for help with a crushing burden — or stop comparing and take one step in your own course.

In one line: Help carry what is too heavy; faithfully carry what is yours.